1 The Stone Age— a Wandering Life

Learning Outcomes

The learner:

- explains that human beings **evolved** from hominins over many thousands of years.
- lists the sources that historians have used to get a picture of the life of early human beings.
- discusses the ways early human beings made tools and weapons.
- explains the important role fire played in the life of early human beings.
- recognizes the beauty of cave art of the very ancient times.
- explains the life of hunter-gatherers in the Palaeolithic and Mesolithic ages.

Let's Take-off

Critical Thinking

This food needs to be cut. Which of these two would do it better?

Roast chicken

Mango

Stone

Knife

Write here why: .....

..... C-1.1

.....

The knife would cut the food better than the stone because it has a sharp edge. It is a tool that helps you cut food.

The earliest people learnt to make **tools** with sharp edges. Their tools are some sources that tell us about them.

THE OLD AND MIDDLE STONE AGES—THE SOURCES

Tools

Most tools were made of stone. Toolmakers hit one stone with another stone until it had a sharp edge. Early tools that could be held comfortably in a human hand are called 'hand axes'. Slowly tools got better—they became thinner and sharper.

An early human being making a stone tool—notice the small pieces of chipped-off stones lying on the ground.

An ancient hand axe—Which side would have been held in the hand?

Some tools, like needles, were made from bones or the antlers of deer. Early people used their tools for hunting, fishing, cutting meat, cleaning animal skins, digging and sewing. This period is called the Stone Age because many stone tools have been found during this period. It was a very long period of time. It had three phases, depending on the type of tools that were used.

The phases of the Stone Age	The tools made and used
Palaeolithic or Old Stone Age (from Greek words Palaeo=ancient; Lithos=stone)	Stone tools, like hand axes, which had sharp edges. Bone and wooden tools were also used.
Mesolithic Age or Middle Stone Age (from Greek, Meso=middle)	Small, sharp stone tools that could be fitted onto wooden arrows or spears
Neolithic Age or New Stone Age (from Greek, Neo=new)	Finer stone tools that were polished to make them sharper. Bone and wooden tools continued to be used.

You will learn about the New Stone Age in the next chapter.

Did You Know?

Two scientists made thousands of stone tools to understand more about early people. They were able to use the tools to cut meat. They realized that making stone tools was hard work and took a lot of practice.

Shelters

Caves used as shelters have also been found. People probably lived in them when it was wet or cold. Some caves have the bones of animals. This tells us which animals were hunted and eaten by these people.

A cave in Europe that was used as a shelter in the Stone Age

Art

A Stone Age cave painting showing people and animals

In several parts of the world, drawings and paintings have been found on the walls of caves. These mainly show animals, though some show people as well. In caves where colours were used, these are still quite bright even though the paintings are very old. It is very dark inside caves, so people probably used fire so that they had enough light to paint by. These drawings and paintings tell us about the animals the people had around them and also how they hunted them.

THE HUNTER-GATHERERS

From these sources, experts can guess what the life of early people was like. At that time, people did not know how to grow their food. Their main aim was to find food to be able to **survive**. They lived by hunting wild animals, fishing, and by searching for and gathering foods such as fruits, nuts, vegetables and honey. We call these people **hunter-gatherers**.

At that time the earth was rich in plant and animal life. The hunter-gatherers depended on this environment for their food. They moved from place to place, wandering over large areas in search of food and water. They had to be near water, but also near areas where their food could be found. They had a very good understanding of their environment and were very skilled at what they needed to do.

The men hunted in groups. They observed and understood the animals they hunted—where they were to be found and how they lived. Some animals they hunted were the elephant, the buffalo, the giraffe, different types of deer and other smaller animals. Animals were probably chased until they became tired and could be killed or until they fell into a deep pit. Perhaps they were chased to a wet, muddy area where they got stuck. Stone tools were then used to kill them and cut the meat so that it could be carried home.

Spears had wooden handles and stone heads. Arrows were also made of wood and had stone arrowheads.

Did You Know?

Caves with beautiful art from the Palaeolithic Age have also been found in northern Spain at Altamira. Most of these paintings, done in natural colours, are on the roofs of the caves.

A stone arrowhead—Talk about how these could have been attached to the spears or arrows.

The women looked after the children and gathered food like fruits, roots, berries and seeds. They knew which plants and seeds could be eaten, when the fruits and berries ripened and where they grew. They used pointed stones and sticks as tools to dig up the roots. All these were very important skills for the hunter-gatherers.

The women gathered fruits, roots and berries. They also looked after the children.

The hunter-gatherers lived in groups of many people because they needed each other—to hunt, to carry food home, to gather food and to look after children.

Wandering about in search of food was not easy but the hunting-gathering way of life survived for thousands of years. This is because these people knew how to live well in their environment and because they were very skilled at what they did.

A Better World

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

Goal 5: Gender Equality

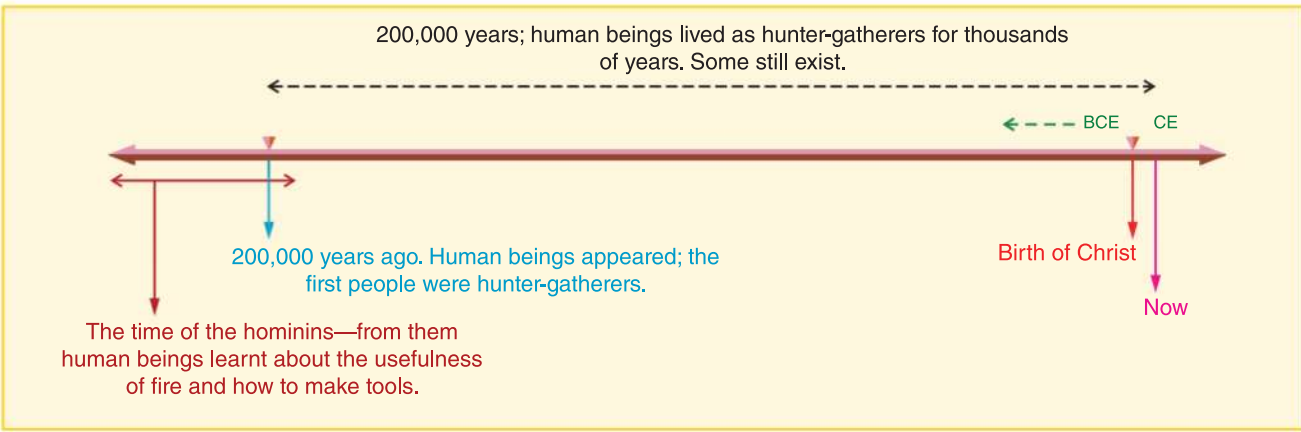
Among the hunter-gatherers, the men went to hunt while the women gathered food and looked after children. Do you think this shows a gender-equal society?

Think and Answer

Critical Thinking

The hunter-gatherers knew and respected their environment as they depended on it to stay alive. Talk about the difference between them and people today. C-2.3

The timeline shows you how long ago human beings appeared and how long they lived as hunter-gatherers. Hunter-gatherers are still found in many parts of the world.



HOTS

Critical Thinking

Why do you think that there are still hunter-gatherers in many parts of the world? C-6.1

Discuss

Communication

Like the hunter-gatherers, people today also belong to groups.

1. Which groups do you belong to?
2. How are they important for you?

C-6.1

HUNTER-GATHERERS IN INDIA

Stone tools of early human beings have been found in several places in India. India also has one of the largest collections of rock paintings in the world. Most of these are in the caves of the Satpura and Vindhya hills in central India. The most famous paintings are at **Bhimbetka** in Madhya Pradesh. Though these are the most well-known, cave paintings belonging to the Stone Age have also been found in the **Lakhudiyar** caves in Uttarakhand. The paintings are found on the walls of natural rock shelters and depict animals, humans and geometric patterns, mostly in black, white and red.

A cave painting from Bhimbetka in Madhya Pradesh—Find their hunting tools in the picture.

Knowledge of India

In several parts of India, tribal communities are hunter-gatherers who depend on forests for their livelihoods. Many now also earn their livelihood through agriculture and other methods of earning.

Values and Life Skills

1. The hunter-gatherers learnt important things from the hominins. Why should we try to learn from the people who lived before us?
2. We should know how to look after ourselves like the hunter-gatherers did. You can learn how to use sharp implements carefully, without hurting yourself or anyone else.

REMEMBER

The Stone Age—a Wandering Life

- The main sources that tell us about the earliest people are their tools, bones, their shelters and cave paintings.
- The earliest human beings were hunter-gatherers.
- Hunter-gatherers lived in groups. They moved from place to place in search of food and water.
- Hunter-gatherers were very skilled and had a good understanding of their environment.
- Hunter-gatherers are still found in some parts of the world, including in India.

NEW WORDS

Evolve to develop gradually

Tool anything that you can hold in your hand, such as a hammer or a knife, which helps to do a piece of work

Survive stay alive

EXERCISES

Remembering and Understanding

A. Choose the correct answers.

1. The hunter-gatherers led a wandering life in search of food/because they liked travelling/because they were trying to survive.
2. As the years went by, the tools of the hunter-gatherers remained the same/became better/became more difficult to use.
3. The hand axe is called by this name because it could be held comfortably in a person's hand/a person's hand could be hurt by using it/they could use it along with a handle.
4. Cave art of the early people has been found only in India/in many parts of the world/only in Europe.
5. Read the statements below and choose the correct option.

   Statement (A): Men and women had different responsibilities.

   Statement (B): Men used to hunt and women used to gather fruits and vegetables.

   (a) Both A and B are true, and B is the correct explanation of A.

   (b) Both A and B are true, but B is not the correct explanation of A.

   (c) A is true but B is false.

   (d) A is false but B is true.

B. Complete the following sentences in your notebook.

1. Two things that human beings learnt from hominins were:

   .....

2. The earliest people are called hunter-gatherers because:

   .....

3. Some animals that the hunter-gatherers hunted were:

   .....

4. Some foods that the hunter-gatherers gathered were:

   .....

5. The period when early human beings lived is called the Stone Age because:

   .....

C. Match the following.

A	B
1. Homo sapiens	(a) The upright man
2. Old Stone Age	(b) Finer stone tools that were polished to make them sharper
3. Middle Stone Age	(c) The thinking man
4. New Stone Age	(d) Sharp stone tools, fixed on wooden arrows or spears
5. Homo erectus	(e) Stone hand axes that had sharp edges

D. You be the teacher!

Here are some answers. Write the questions for them in your notebook.

1. We learn about early humans from bones, tools, shelters and cave paintings.
2. They were made of stones, bones and antlers.
3. They are found in the Vindhya and Satpura hills. Bhimbetka in Madhya Pradesh has the best-known ones.
4. Some skills were making tools, hunting animals, gathering plant food, understanding the environment, drawing and painting and living well with other people.
5. The hunter-gatherers needed each other.

E. Answer the following questions.

1. What do we call the people who lived on earth before human beings?
2. How did the hunter-gatherers make their stone tools?
3. What did the hunter-gatherers use their tools for?
4. Write three or four sentences about caves as a source of information about the hunter-gatherers. Mention the remains found there and the art.
5. What was the main aim of the hunter-gatherers?
6. How did men and women divide their responsibilities during the Stone Age? Write a short paragraph to explain.

DO AND LEARN

21st CENTURY SKILLS

A. Picture Study

Look at the pictures and answer the following questions.

1. What is the difference in the materials used to make these tools?
2. Which tool would be easier to hold? Why?
3. What are the similarities between the food of the Stone Age people and people today?

C-6.1 Critical Thinking

B. On Your Own

Then and now: Cave artists used colours made from natural materials. Try to do similar paintings on stones. Have a class display of your stone paintings. Use:

1. Yellow turmeric mixed in water
2. Red ochre mixed in water (This is used to paint earthen flowerpots.)
3. Charcoal or soft coal for black lines

C-6.2 Creativity

C. In a Group

1. **Try some magic:** Early human beings used stones called flints to light fires. You can also create sparks from stones. Make sure that you have an adult with you when you do this. Take two stones (not bricks) and strike them against each other in a dark corner. You may be able to see the magical sparks.

   Experiential Learning SI Arts Education

2. **Talk and present:** Did Stone Age people have a carefree life?
   (a) Talk about this in your group. What has your group decided and why?
   (b) Present the result of your discussion to the rest of the class.

   C-6.2 Collaboration

D. Pair and Share

With your partner in class, discuss how life is different now as compared to the Stone Age.

C-6.1 Communication

TP

Weblink For more information, go to:

Virtual Tour of Lascaux Cave: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2GhMaBlazFY (Accessed on 31 July 2025)

What I Learnt

Self-review

Colour the smileys to show how well you have understood the concepts.	Completely	Mostly	Need help
• I can explain that human beings evolved from hominins over many thousands of years.	☺	☺	☺
• I can list the sources that historians have used to get a picture of the life of early human beings.	☺	☺	☺
• I can discuss the way early human beings made tools and weapons.	☺	☺	☺
• I can explain the important role fire played in the life of early human beings.	☺	☺	☺
• I can recognize the beauty of cave art of the very ancient times.	☺	☺	☺
• I can explain the life of hunter-gatherers in the Palaeolithic and Mesolithic ages.	☺	☺	☺